



MONTHLY UPDATE

West Africa: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-02 • 23 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES • INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION •
SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE • COORDINATION AND COLLABORATION • CAPACITY AND INCLUSION • FINANCE

Summary of the month

The month's largest financial commitment was the West African Development Bank and KfW's Digital Transformation Fund, a 71 billion FCFA facility for public-administration modernisation across the monetary union, alongside a [EUR10.5m African Development Bank stake in a pan-African start-up fund](#). ECOWAS changed leadership, installing a new Commission president on 31 August, while its central bank reported the union's instant-payment rail moving from test phase to full operation and its own interbank switch losing its director-general to an unexplained departure. Payment systems kept growing on the figures the base holds: 104 institutions authorised on PI-SPI and 78 issuing electronic money across the union, both up sharply on a year earlier. A press-freedom organisation reported cybercrime statutes in Burkina Faso, Mali, Niger and Guinea being used against journalists, and a four-country study found none of the region's states yet holds AI-specific legislation in force or in draft.

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

The regional central bank's banking commission [published its 2025 annual report on 27 August](#), recording the union's instant-payment platform — which had reached [30 million users within ten months of launch](#) — as fully operational rather than in test phase, with the bank [participating in the ECOWAS payment project and preparing a pilot accession to the continental equivalent](#).

The ECOWAS Commission [installed General Birame Diop as its new president on 31 August](#), succeeding the leadership that had carried Vision 2050 and the February 2010 Supplementary Act — still the newest regional digital instrument the base holds — through to this handover.

Officials from ten member states [validated the orientations of a revised postal-sector Directive and the outline of a Regional Postal Master Plan 2027-2030 at Lomé on 12-13 August](#), naming digital transformation, e-commerce, universal-service modernisation, consumer protection and financial inclusion as priority areas. The meeting was an expert validation rather than an adoption, and consultations with member states continue with neither text published.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

A West Africa Feminist Data Summit at Porto-Novo [ratified a Regional Feminist Data Agenda 2026-2028 at its close on 30 July](#), setting three priorities for the period, each with a named owner, alongside eight thematic policy briefs and a cross-border encrypted data collective with rapid-response protocols. [The organisers put attendance at a hundred delegates from twenty-one countries](#); the figures are the organisers' own, and no text of the agenda itself is published.

Instruments and harmonisation

Strategies, plans and policies

The central bank of the West African Monetary Union [is running a structured internal process on cryptoassets](#) rather than drafting a regime: a questionnaire sent to fintech operators, a dedicated committee named C-CRYPTO, and a high-level international conference held in May 2026, [reported also as part of a broader fintech-led digitalisation push across the union](#). Cryptoassets remain outside legal tender and no instrument has been issued; the bank's own question, as the account gives it, is how to admit the instruments without compromising monetary stability, the CFA franc's issuance monopoly or the integrity of the regional financial system. The account is a legal academic's analysis published in a trade outlet rather than a central-bank statement, and neither the questionnaire's findings, the committee's membership and terms, nor any conference output is held.

Legislation and regulation

A press-freedom organisation [reported the cybercrime statutes of Burkina Faso, Mali, Niger and Guinea being used to prosecute journalists](#), presented at a press-freedom conference on 14 August, and called for the repeal of the vague public-order and human-dignity provisions the statutes carry. The finding is one organisation's; no government response and no case count are held.

Standards

Domain-name practitioners [announced an initiative to coordinate country-code domain policy across the region](#) — the Alliance ouest-africaine des noms de domaine — with the founding case put to the SIPEN-UEMOA trade fair in Ouagadougou on 15 July. The alliance was convened by practitioners rather than by the registries or a regional body, and no charter, membership or founding act is held.

AI

The ECOWAS Regional AI Governance Framework, resolved at a Lagos thematic dialogue in January, remains undrafted six months on: no draft text, drafting body or timetable is held. A four-country comparative study presented on 10 August [found none of Benin, Senegal, Cote d'Ivoire or Burkina Faso holds AI-specific legislation in force or in draft](#), rating Cote d'Ivoire's strategy the most advanced of the four on inclusion and data governance and finding Burkina Faso's data-protection law the only one of the four to name AI-based processing.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

Nigerian and Burkinabe officials, meeting at a ministerial visit to Ouagadougou on 13 August, [discussed a connectivity partnership under Nigeria's Project BRIDGE aimed at halving the cost of internet access in Burkina Faso](#), with technical teams to assess routes through Niger and through Benin. The discussion is exploratory: no agreement, route, cost or date is settled, and [the 50% figure is a stated aim rather than a commitment](#).

Cybersecurity

The Commission named an Information Sharing and Analysis Centre as established under its [Joint Platform for Advancing Cybersecurity](#) — funded by Germany's Federal Foreign Office and implemented by GIZ — as the region's threat-intelligence sharing platform; no founding instrument, membership, feed or published output is held.

Separately, an eight-month international police operation targeting West African organised-crime groups [concluded with 58 arrests](#). The account is regional and does not break the arrests down by member state.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The regional interbank electronic-payments switch, GIM-UEMOA, [is running under an interim chief executive](#) after its director-general — in post since March 2020 — left the role on 12 August; no reason for the departure and no timetable for a permanent appointment is stated.

The instant-payment platform PI-SPI [held 104 authorised institutions at 31 July](#), against 80 connected at 24 June and 74 at the end of December 2025 — up from 45 at its September 2025 launch — with Senegal (24) and Cote d'Ivoire (23) holding nearly half between them, ahead of Mali (14), Burkina Faso (13), Benin (11), Togo (9) and Guinea-Bissau and Niger (5 each). The July figure counts institutions authorised and the June figure institutions connected, so the two are not measured on the same base.

The banking commission's 2025 annual report [puts electronic-money issuance at 78 institutions at 31 December 2025 against 63 a year earlier](#) — 59 banks in partnership with telecommunications operators or technical providers, 18 licensed electronic-money issuers (up from 14, on approvals for Djogana Pay in Cote d'Ivoire, QuickPay SA and TouchPoint Financial Services in Senegal, and Tmoney in Togo), one microfinance institution and four national treasuries also issuing, concentrated in Senegal (5) and Cote d'Ivoire (4). Provisional data on 17 of the 18 licensed issuers [puts turnover at FCFA 323.2bn, up 12%, outstanding electronic money at FCFA 1,923.2bn, up 35.2%, and profit at FCFA 16.9bn against FCFA 6.1bn in 2024](#).

Sectoral management information systems

A four-day ECOWAS Commission training on the ASRII Digital Platform — the African Union's harmonised framework for measuring regional integration, developed with the regional economic communities, UNECA and the African Development Bank — [closed at Abuja on 7 August](#) with twenty core participants trained across the Commission's directorates and the Directorate of Research and Statistics named as the single focal point. The platform is meant to replace manual collection with submission, validation, automated computation of integration scores and dissemination, evaluating member states' policy implementation and tracking commitments across sectors; no integration score has been published. At the closing the Secretary General called for a centralised database of the status, amendments and implications of all regional legal protocols, and for a blueprint for regional data management — the Commission holds neither.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A regional tax-administration forum project, financed by a grant the African Development Fund's transition support facility [dates to on or before 11 March and states at US\\$5.52m, launched on 18 August](#) under a forum-hosted project implementation unit and a multi-stakeholder steering committee, running to 30 July 2030. A later account of the launch [puts the grant at 4 million units of account, about US\\$5.3m](#) — the two figures are not reconciled — and the project's digital component, its component allocations and its results framework are not itemised anywhere published.

National statistics

Two regional statistics workshops convened at Abidjan on 18-22 August under the Commission's research and statistics directorate: a second operationalisation workshop training national coordination and economic policy committee members to apply the common regional frameworks for compiling and publishing macroeconomic statistics, moving the Regional Statistical Programme 2023-2027 from adopted guidelines toward guides in active use, and [the sixth Regional Coordination Meeting, which reviewed and validated the third edition of the Regional Report on International Migration in West Africa](#). Participants at both [reviewed the two regional statistical databases and took up harmonisation of member states' 2000-2025 national series for multilateral surveillance](#).

Coordination and collaboration

Innovation ecosystem

The Commission's private sector and industry directorate [launched a second edition of the ECOWAS Startup Awards, announced at Abuja on 17 August](#), offering scaling technology-led businesses managerial training, venture funding and cross-border expansion support within the continental free trade area. The announcement was a press briefing; no prize fund, entry deadline, cohort size or outcome from the first edition is published.

Capacity and inclusion

Training and skills

The monetary union's central bank training centre, COFEB, [opened the fourth edition of its certifying programme in digital finance with Luxembourg's House of Training-ATTF](#), applications closing 25 August: four modules over about nine months and 84 hours, aimed at senior staff of credit institutions, e-money issuers and microfinance institutions, one candidate per institution, a participation fee of FCFA 1.2m, an 80% pass mark per module and a final project defended before a jury at Dakar. No cohort size or completion figures for the earlier three editions are published.

Separately, [38 professionals from member states and partner institutions trained at Lomé from 4 to 6 August](#) to assess the maturity of national computer security incident response teams, under the Security Incident Management Maturity Model owned by the Open CSIRT Foundation and hosted by Cyber Defense Africa, operator of Togo's CERT.tg; the Commission states a further aim of a sustainable pool of West African trainers.

Finance

New investments

The West African Development Bank and Germany's KfW [published the terms of a joint Digital Transformation Fund](#) carrying an envelope of 71 billion FCFA for digital modernisation of public administrations across the union's eight member states: a six-step instruction and validation process, a named focal point in each state, and eligibility terms of a maximum 24-month project, a budget ceiling of 2,500 million FCFA, an interest rate the fund states at 2.2% and obligatory partial state co-financing. A trade-press account of 19 August [puts the rate at 2.77%](#) — the fund's own figure is carried here and the two are not reconciled — and no date of signature or entry into force, no country allocation and no committed or disbursed total is published.

Separately, the African Development Bank [approved EUR10.5m toward the first close of a pan-African start-up fund](#) on 9 August under the Boost Africa programme with the European Investment Bank — EUR7m from the Bank and EUR3.5m jointly from the European Union and the African, Caribbean and Pacific states, not separately disclosed — investing in agribusiness, financial services, energy, education and health mainly in Francophone West Africa.

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